

Quant vs. Qual

Different Approaches to Social Science Methodology

Colin Hannigan

CSB/SJU

POLS 222: Slide Deck #9

WDWTALT?

Operationalization: the process of turning “squishy” concepts into “firm,” consistent, comprehensible, measurable observations.

1. Precision (the measure contains lots of information).
2. Reliability (the measure is consistent on repeat trials).
3. Validity (the measure is accurate to the concept).

Face validity: does it measure the concept how we want to measure it?

Content validity: does it capture the full range of meanings of the concept it is supposed to measure?

Four levels of measurement:

- Nominal (categories with no clear order).
- Ordinal (categories that have a natural order).
- Dichotomous (two categories).
- Continuous/Interval (not categories—order *and* distance between values matter).

What are the differences between qualitative analysis and quantitative analysis?

Which one uses data?

What are the differences between qualitative analysis and quantitative analysis?

Which one uses data?

- **Both! Data is information; not just numbers!**

Some Patterns of Difference

	Qual	Quant
Focus	Focus on individual cases/units	Focus on many cases/units at once
Comparison	Within- or cross-case/unit analysis	Cross-case/unit analysis
Number of cases	Smaller- <i>N</i> (number of obs.)	Larger- <i>N</i> (number of obs.)
Testing Emphasis	Causal mechanisms	Generalizability
Evidence type	Allows for flexibility in evidence type	Uses specific statistical tests of numerical data
Perks	Deeper understanding of case(s)	Often easier to replicate by others

Complementing Approaches

Different VSWRQs lend themselves to different approaches:

- What explains the U.S. decision to enter World War I?
- What is the relationship between democracy and development?
- Why does social media mobilize resistance in some cases but not others?

Quant and qual have complementary strengths:

- Examine outlier cases *qualitatively* to generate causal theories.
- Test generalizability of causal theory *quantitatively*.

Use 'em both!